

RANCHI | Encounter Furore

Jharkhand, which is under President's Rule, is in the news for more wrong reasons after its police exonerated CRPF personnel for an "encounter" during which five "Naxals" were killed. The "encounter" took place on April 15, a day before the first phase of elections, near Latehar district when Maoists triggered a landmine blast and fired at a bus carrying CRPF personnel. Two cops, a civilian driver and a helper were killed in the ambush. The police claimed that the security personnel fired back in self-defence and five "Naxalites" were killed. Villagers, however, claim that security personnel dragged the victims out of their village and killed them, suspecting them to be rebel conduits. Among the victims, three were students while one was an



CPI(M) WORKERS IN RANCHI PROTEST THE FAKE ENCOUNTER

employee of Central Coalfields Limited. On April 24, after a sustained public outcry, the Jharkhand Police conceded that the dead were innocent. A magisterial probe has now been ordered into the incident.

by Amitabh Srivastava

Right Echo

Poles apart they may be, but in backing the BJP's call that the prime minister must be an elected Lok Sabha member, the CPI(M) has sent a far-from-subtle message to the Congress—drop Manmohan Singh, who is from the Rajya Sabha, and we can do business again.

DELHI | Gold Plated Galleon



The Spanish navy's newest multi-purpose stealth frigate, the *Blas de Lezo*, sailed into Mumbai this week with its maker, Spanish shipyard Navantia drumming up a look-at-me sales pitch. The reason: the Indian Navy recently floated request for proposals to global shipyards, including

Navantia, for buying and later indigenously building seven Project 17-A frigates. But there's nothing stealthy about the price of the imported warships like the Spanish ship. "A single F-100 destroyer (Navantia-designed) for the Australian Navy costs as much as all the three Kolkata class destroyers being built at Mazagon Docks," an Indian naval admiral shrugs. The three indigenously designed Kolkata class warships, including *Chennai* and *Hyderabad*, being built not very far from where the Spanish naval ship is anchored, costs Rs 11,000 crore. These Indian-built warships have achieved an indigenous content of nearly 80 per cent. Which leads to the question: why are tenders being sent out to foreign shipyards when the capability to build them exists within the country?

by Sandeep Unnithan

Bout of the Box

Distance does not make the heart grow fonder. That's the verdict from the TAM ratings of the first IPL weekend. The ratings for Season Two in South Africa were lower than for Season One. The highest rating came in from the Chennai Super Kings and Royal Challengers Bangalore match.

2008 ratings

KKR vs BRC	8.21
CSK vs KP	4.97
RR vs DD	5.58
DC vs KKR	7.14
MI vs RCB	7.16
KP vs RR	5.51
DC vs DD	4.90

2009 ratings

CSK vs MI	5.55
RR vs RCB	5.48
KP vs DD	5.08
KKR vs DC	5.34
CSK vs RCB	6.02
KP vs KKR	3.64
MI vs RR	Abandoned

Could it be the absence of buzz? The comparatively lower scores? Mandira Bedi's so-last-season hair cut? Viewer fatigue? Brr. We can hear the chill go down SetMax's spine.

KKR: Kolkata Knight Riders; BRC: Bangalore Royal Chargers; CSK: Chennai Super Kings; KP: Kings XI Punjab; RR: Rajasthan Royals; DD: Delhi Daredevils; DC: Deccan Chargers; MI: Mumbai Indians.